then?’ Slowly, I calmed down. Maa gently placed me on the ground and reached for the puppy, who at first scrambled deeper inside the leaves, but Maa picked it up in her right hand. I clapped and giggled as she smiled at me. A drop of rain fell on my cheek where the trail of tears had just dried. The puppy’s large eyes were fixed on me. I held Maa’s left hand and, together, the three of us marched back inside our house.

It rained cats and dogs that afternoon. Inside, Maa bathed me and my new friend, dried us both and sat us on the veranda when Papaji’s Gypsy arrived. Papaji held Dada close and rushed inside as his driver followed him, holding an umbrella that hardly saved them from the incessant rain. ‘A puppy!’ Dada exclaimed happily on seeing the pup sitting next to me, freed himself from Papaji’s arm and ran towards us. ‘Can we keep him? Are we keeping him?’ he asked.

‘Where did he come from?’ a surprised Papaji asked Maa. ‘Your daughter rescued this one,’ Maa said. ‘Go change first, I’ll tell you about it over lunch.’ Papaji gazed at me, smiled and nodded. Meanwhile, Dada petted the puppy with his wet hands.

Papaji was able to convince Maa and they mutually agreed to let the pup stay. Chimpu became an inseparable member of the family in no time. Dada named the puppy after one of the characters in Grandmother’s bedtime stories. For a few days I resisted going to the playschool in the morning, and spent the entire time with Chimpu. Papaji got him vaccinated and brought home dog food. Maa made sure of the hygiene in and around the house—‘Chimpu will not sleep in your bed’ and ‘Chimpu will not eat from your hands’. She set ground rules in the house only to see them broken every day. Chimpu’s brown hair could be found everywhere—on the sofa, on the carpet, on the veranda, in the bathroom, on our beds and on our clothes. He even went on the occasional picnic with us. Papaji would put him in his scooter’s front basket during the journey. I was happy. I made a lot of memories with Chimpu. Happy memories.

One afternoon in September, Maa was taking a nap, while Chimpu, Dada and I played on the veranda under Papaji’s supervision. Dada and I chased Chimpu, who manoeuvred quicker than the two of us. In a daring attempt to